



ANUSHKA BHATNAGAR
Publishing Lead - India &
South Asia, Riot Games

RIOT'S INDIA VISION

VALORANT, COMMUNITY, AND MAKING OF INDIAN ESPORTS

Jayesh Shinde | editor@digit.in

Riot Games has never treated India like a checkbox market. As VALORANT continues to anchor the country's PC esports ecosystem, Riot's India leadership is thinking less about viral moments and more about trust, pathways, and longevity. Anushka Bhatnagar, Publishing Lead – India & South Asia at Riot Games, explains what that long game looks like as India heads into 2026 and 2027.

How would you describe Riot's commitment and long-term strategy for the Indian market?

Anushka: Riot's commitment to India has always been rooted in patience and presence rather than collecting quick wins. Over the last few years, our focus has been on listening closely, understanding how players here engage with games, esports, and culture, and then building in a way that feels sustainable and respectful of that reality.

As we look toward 2026 and 2027, our long-term strategy is centred on deepening what already exists rather than constantly reinventing it. We want players to feel that there is room to grow, whether they're aspiring professionals, creators, or people who

simply play to connect and unwind with friends. Ultimately, our commitment to India isn't tied to a single title or season. It's about building an ecosystem that players can trust over the long term, one that grows with them and continues to feel relevant as the community evolves.

What do you think made VALORANT click so well with Indian gamers?

Anushka: VALORANT clicked in India because it felt familiar in the best way. It's a game built around teamwork and shared wins, the same way PC gaming has always lived here, in cyber cafes, hostels, and late-night sessions with friends. In VALORANT, players found something that reflected how they already played and connected.

It also gave players a strong sense of identity. From Harbor to Lotus, to specific playstyles and the slang that grew around it, the community quickly made VALORANT its own. To keep that momentum going into 2027, staying close to the community is key. VALORANT Challengers South Asia provides a clear competitive pathway and shared moments that fans can rally around, whether they're aspiring pros or dedicated viewers. Alongside that, our focus is on showing up in the spaces where players already are

and letting the community continue to shape how VALORANT lives beyond the screen.

What are the biggest challenges when it comes to publishing games in India, and how is Riot tackling them?

Anushka: Publishing games in India comes with a unique set of challenges, particularly around cultural nuance and regulatory frameworks. India isn't a single, uniform market, it's a collection of cultures, languages, and social contexts, and players are quick to notice when something doesn't feel locally grounded. Understanding what resonates and what feels authentic requires constant listening and on-the-ground context.

There are also important government requirements and protocols around entertainment and digital products that need to be navigated carefully. Compliance, data considerations, age ratings, and evolving regulatory expectations all play a role in how games are published and operated.

For us, publishing in India is about serving the community in a balanced way – staying true to the core of our games while being mindful of local culture and governance. That balance is what allows us to build trust and grow sustainably with the community. **d**